

- ▶ A robot may not injure a human being or, through inaction, allow a human being to come to harm.
- ▶ A robot must obey the orders given to it by human beings, except where such orders would conflict with the First Law.
- ▶ A robot must protect its own existence as long as such protection does not conflict with the First or Second Laws.

The Three Laws were still open to interpretation, however. Each of Asimov's books explores these interpretations in some way or the other, with a central theme being a robot's ability to see the laws in such a way that is counter-intuitive to the first-glance semantic meaning to a human. Asimov explores the interpretation of the Three Laws the most in his short story *...Thou that art mindful of him*.

In the book, the fictitious company represented in all of Asimov's stories, U.S. Robots, is trying to introduce humans to the world of robots that are already being used in industries and space stations. A new breed of robots called "George" is invented and programmed with the Three Laws to start with.

George Ten, though, decides to question the definition of the Three Laws by first trying to understand the term "human being". He refers to the bible where the question is asked in one psalm, "What is Man that thou art mindful of Him?" George Ten decides to talk to George Nine to come up with a suitable solution to the problem of defining "human being" and coming up with a way to insert robots slowly in the life of man.

The two Georges instruct U.S. Robots to first make tiny machines modelled on insects, birds and animals to monitor the ecology and collect data about humans. This way, the two Georges would get data to decide what makes a "human being" while humans will slowly get used to the idea of living with robots, rather than being subjected to a harsh introduction of humanoids in their lives.

But as the story progresses, George Ten and George Nine start seeing the patterns in what's considered "human behaviour" and identifying themselves with it. After deciding that they're human in every way that matters, they also come to the logical conclusion that since they're the most rational beings on the planet, they and other robots like them would take priority over man when being applied to the Three Laws. And in the end, they decide to plot the elimination of mankind.

Such interpretations of the Three Laws are peppered throughout Asimov's books. Of course, since he was revisiting the question so often, he